

AGEING WARHORSE: A Harrier hovering in to land on the *Viraat*



HOVER AND OUT

Over half of the Navy's fleet of Sea Harriers has crashed leaving a void in its air defence capability. With the aircraft going out of production there is little scope of future procurement also.

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

It was past 11 on a warm Monday morning when Commander Janak Bevli's Sea Harrier came to land on the tarmac on the naval air station at Goa's picturesque Dabolim airport. It was not an ordinary fighter aircraft landing, Commander Bevli gently rotated the Sea Harrier's Vertical/Short Take Off and Landing (V/STOL) thrust nozzles down towards the runway, bringing the aircraft to a gentle hover. Just then, the aircraft began yawing out of control. In a flash the experienced pilot yanked the twin handles of the Martin Baker ejection seat between his thighs. His seat rocketed out of the cockpit into the sky. The parachute blossomed minutes after the aircraft thudded on the concrete. Bevli escaped unscathed but his aircraft became the 17th Sea Harrier of a total fleet of 30 aircraft to crash since their induction in 1983. Seven pilots have been killed so far. Six of the ageing aircraft have crashed in the past five years, three in the past 12 months alone. The Indian Navy's fleet of Sea

Harrier now hovers at a perilously low figure of 13 aircraft—nine fighters and four twin-seat trainers—which raises serious doubts on its capability to defend its fleet at the sea.

Among the greatest threats for a carrier battle group out at the sea is from long-range maritime patrol and strike (LRMP/S) aircraft which operate far beyond the range of the ship's sensors and surface-to-air missiles. An LRMP/S like the P3-C Orion can fire up to four Harpoon missiles, each with a range of over 120 km. A single hit from an anti-ship missile can disable a carrier and prevent it from launching aircraft. The only weapon the navy has to speedily intercept enemy aircraft are the Sea Harrier jump jets.

Now consider this alarming scenario. Over the next five years, the task of protecting the carrier battle group—the *Viraat*, destroyers, frigates

and fleet tankers—will fall on just nine Harriers or just half a squadron of aircraft. This is less than half the required strength of fighter aircraft. This scenario has been worsened by the fact that the refit of the aircraft carrier *Vikramaditya*, which India bought from Russia, has been delayed by four years and it will arrive only in 2012. *Vikramaditya*'s air group of 18 MiG-29K carrier-capable aircraft will start arriving in batches on time, from next year. The MiG-29s, however, cannot operate from the *Viraat*'s specially-built ski-jump on the flight deck and hence will be shore-based until the *Vikramaditya* arrives.

There are three main reasons why the aircraft crash—pilot error, faulty maintenance schedule or the failure of a spare part. The navy says it is concerned but has refused to divulge reasons behind the spate of crashes which have

The Indian Navy is left with only nine Sea Harrier fighter aircraft to protect its growing Blue Water fleet